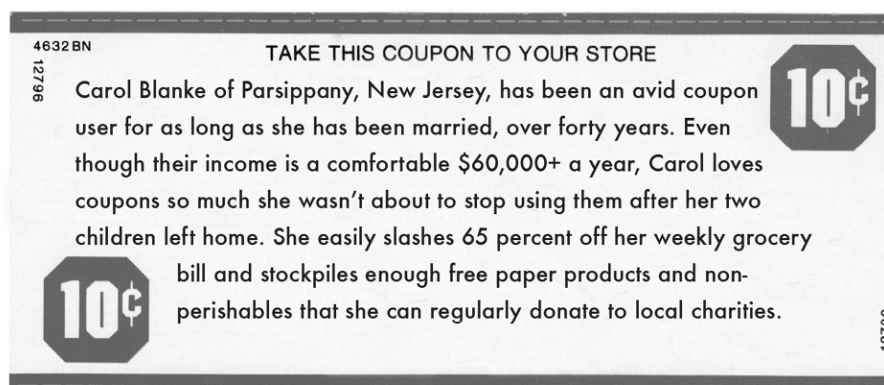


It isn't as simple as that; clipping one coupon doesn't automatically mean a savings. The consumer has to remember to take it to the store and redeem it for that product before there is an actual savings. And even then, if they don't actually need the product or a cheaper generic is available, then the coupon really isn't saving them money at all. Still, Arend's low-finance math perspective is not without merit. It is true; the savings can really add up.



Several years ago, I visited with a friend who began lauding the praises of a new brand of canned chili bean product she'd tried and loved. "I have coupons for those you can have!" I exclaimed. "You can get one free with every can you buy."

"No!" her husband protested from across the room. "No coupons!" His booming baritone stopped me in my tracks. Was he kidding? I wasn't sure, so I looked at my friend.

She leaned in closer and whispered apologetically, "He won't let me use coupons. He thinks only poor people use them."